

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 181

By Clemmons

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor Carol Westlake on the occasion of her retirement.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to specially recognize those estimable Tennesseans who have dedicated themselves to improving the quality of life for their fellow citizens; and

WHEREAS, Carol Westlake is one such individual, who, after thirty-five devoted years of service, is taking her well-deserved retirement from the Tennessee Disability Coalition (TDC), an organization she founded and ably stewarded as executive director; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Westlake founded the TDC, then known as the Coalition for Community Services, in 1987 and officially became the organization's executive director on November 1, 1990; what began as an informal, four-person cohort of disability advocates has grown, due in large part to Ms. Westlake's efforts, into a thriving, leading voice within the halls of the General Assembly and across the Volunteer State; and

WHEREAS, the TDC is now a 501(c)3 nonprofit alliance of more than forty member organizations and individuals who promote the full and equal participation of people with disabilities in all aspects of life, advocating collectively for self-determination, independence, empowerment, and inclusion through various programs and public policy; and

WHEREAS, a lifelong advocate for children and adults with disabilities, Ms. Westlake has helped to establish a number of disability advocacy programs and agencies in Tennessee and helped pass laws to protect the rights of Tennesseans with disabilities; and

WHEREAS, in her years at the helm of TDC, she had a profound impact on Tennessee public policy that affects Tennesseans with disabilities; a core value that guided her work in her decades-long advocacy on issues like voting, education, employment, health care, and housing

was the right and ability of all individuals to make choices about their own lives based on their individual wants and needs; and

WHEREAS, apart from her impact on legislation in Tennessee, Ms. Westlake has been tapped for her expert counsel by the administrations of six U.S. presidents, five Tennessee governors, eight Metro Nashville mayors, and countless other State, county, and business leaders; and

WHEREAS, she has been duly recognized for her good work over the years, receiving the American Association of People with Disabilities (AAPD) Justice for All Disability Rights Award, the organization's highest honor, for her extraordinary leadership in support of the economic and political empowerment of all people with disabilities; other recipients of this honor include Ted Kennedy, Orrin Hatch, John McCain, and Bob Dole; and

WHEREAS, Carol Westlake also received the 2024 Linda O'Neal Lifetime Achievement Award from the Tennessee Commission on Children and Youth; in addition to being a respected leader in the disability advocacy community in Tennessee and throughout the country, she has served as a mentor and teacher for the next generation; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Westlake's legacy with the TDC is an exemplar for effective leadership: identifying an unmet need or unrealized goal, sharing it with others to get buy-in, and building a coalition to achieve it; and

WHEREAS, throughout her tenure as executive director of the TDC, Ms. Westlake has carried out her responsibilities with diligence and integrity; and

WHEREAS, her remarkable success as a public servant and civic leader has been directly attributable to her reliance on the time-honored values of hard work and common sense and her uncommon ability to work well with people from all walks of life; and

WHEREAS, an unwavering advocate for individuals with disabilities in Tennessee, Ms. Westlake has compiled a singular record of success during her exemplary career, and she should be specially recognized; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we recognize and honor Carol Westlake on the occasion of her retirement as executive director of the Tennessee Disability Coalition, extending our best wishes for every future success and happiness.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.